

THE BELIEF INVENTORY — APPLIED

ASSIGNMENT · LECTURE 2.1 · EMPTY YOUR CUP

Write Living Fiction Characters ·

You've named the belief you brought into this course. Now bring it to bear on a specific character from your own work.

Use a character you've struggled with — one who feels flat, or whose voice keeps slipping into yours. Work through the three steps below. Write actual sentences, not notes.

The only rule: use a character you haven't solved yet.

This isn't an exercise in what's going well. It's a diagnostic for what isn't.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN — NAME YOUR CHARACTER

Write down the character's name and a one-sentence description of who they are in your story.

CHARACTER NAME + ONE-SENTENCE DESCRIPTION

STEP ONE — NAME THE BELIEF

What do you tell yourself when this character doesn't work on the page?

Not what you'd tell a writing group. The sentence you say to yourself — the one that comes back every time a scene with this character falls flat.

Some writers hear:

1. I don't know her well enough yet.
2. He sounds like everyone else — I can't find his voice.
3. She's important to the plot but I'm not sure who she actually is.

Write yours below. One sentence. Don't soften it.

THE BELIEF I CARRY ABOUT THIS CHARACTER

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STEP TWO — WHERE DOES THIS SHOW UP?

Name one scene where the belief sent you to the wrong repair.

Think of a specific moment when this character didn't work and you tried to fix it. What did you do — and what did you never question about that fix?

Example: I told myself the scene was flat because I hadn't given her enough backstory. I added backstory. It was still flat. What I never questioned was whether she actually needed backstory — or whether I just hadn't yet asked what she was hiding in that moment.

SCENE / WHAT I TRIED / WHAT I NEVER QUESTIONED

STEP THREE — SET IT DOWN

Write the belief. Then write what becomes uncertain if you let it go.

Repeat the belief from Step One. Then answer: if you set that belief aside for the duration of this course — just for this character — what would you have to be willing to not know?

THE BELIEF:

WHAT BECOMES UNCERTAIN IF I SET IT DOWN:

For the duration of this course, I'm setting this down.

Sign and date this page. Write your name and today's date in the space below.

The act of signing is the marker. The cup-emptying move has to be intentional, or it doesn't take.

SIGNATURE / DATE